



Same Method, Different Box

A Preregistered Replication at a Street-Corner Book Exchange

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Background

A 2026 School of Emergent Priorities study found a community fridge's donation category predicted restock speed better than its apparent urgency. Does the same category effect travel to a different everyday exchange site — the street-corner book box?

Aims

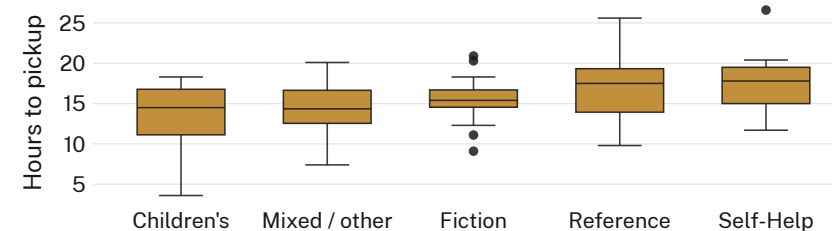
- Replicate the category-predicts-response-speed effect using book genre and time-to-pickup
- Pre-register the genre taxonomy and pickup threshold before logging begins
- Test whether shelf-facing outperforms genre where genre fails to predict

Methods

- n = 214 · 5 suburban boxes · twice-daily photo log · 11 weeks
- five-category genre taxonomy pre-registered from the original fridge coding scheme
- spine orientation (cover-out vs. spine-out) held and recorded as a covariate

Results

Genre category shows no reliable association with time-to-pickup. Spine orientation predicts it closely: cover-out titles clear in a median 6.1 hours against 21.4 for spine-out, regardless of category.



Median hours-to-pickup across five pre-registered genre categories ranges from 14.6 to 16.8 (n = 214, five boxes, Mar–May 2026) — narrower than the 3.3-to-26.0-hour spread the original fridge taxonomy produced across four categories.

Discussion & conclusions

The category effect that organised restock speed at the fridge does not travel to the book box. Display orientation does the work genre did there, at a comparable margin. Next: testing whether cover-out placement follows a rotating curatorial hand or arrives at random.

References

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We thank the residents who maintain the five monitored boxes. No book-identifying information retained beyond genre code and spine orientation; box locations not published.

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“Genre predicted nothing. Which way the spine faced did.”

A pre-registered replication attempt across five suburban book boxes, 214 titles, 11 weeks.